Sentence Starters That Guide the Reader

Australian Curriculum v9.0 · Year 6
English
(Year 5 review skill)
AC9E5LA04

🎒 Back to School 2027 Warm-Up

Name: _____ Date: _____

LEARNING INTENTION

I can choose the starting point of a sentence to give prominence to my message and guide the reader through a text.

I CAN…

- ✓ find the starting point of a sentence
- ✓ change it to put the focus on time, place or manner
- ✓ vary my sentence starters to link ideas

KEY STRATEGY AND WORKED EXAMPLE

The **starting point** is the first idea in a sentence. It tells the reader what to notice first and links to the sentence before it.

The wombat shuffled out of the burrow at dusk. ← focus on the animal
At dusk, the wombat shuffled out of the burrow. ← focus on **time**
Out of the burrow shuffled the wombat. ← focus on **place**

Watch Out! Put a comma after an opening phrase: **After lunch, the class went outside.**

A. TRY TOGETHER – USE THE STRATEGY

1. Rewrite, starting with the time: **The class waited quietly in the library after lunch.**

_____

_____

2. Rewrite, starting with the time: **A storm hit the coast on Monday night.**

_____

_____

3. Rewrite, starting with the place: **The kookaburra laughed from the gum tree.**

_____

_____

B. CORE PRACTICE – SHOW YOUR THINKING

4. **Underline the starting phrase.**
   At the end of the day, the bell rang loudly.
   Without a sound, the owl glided past.
   Beneath the old bridge, a platypus slipped into the creek.

B. CORE PRACTICE (CONTINUED)

5 **Does the starting phrase focus on time, place or manner (how)?**

- Slowly, the tide crept over the sand. _____
- By the end of Term 1, the garden was blooming. _____
- Behind the shed, we found a baby possum. _____

6 Rewrite so the **place** comes first: The wind howled across the paddock all night.

7 Rewrite so the **time** comes first: The students cheered loudly when the team scored.

8 These sentences all start the same way. Rewrite them as one short paragraph with **different starting points** that link the ideas: The ranger walked along the track. The ranger saw a koala. The ranger took a photo.

C. CHALLENGE – WRITE AND JUSTIFY

9 **Analyse.** Ella changed The bushfire swept through the valley. to Through the valley swept the bushfire. How does the new starting point change what the reader notices? Which version builds more suspense, and why?

10 Write a **3-sentence paragraph** about arriving at school on the first day of Term 1. Start each sentence with a different type of starting point: one about **time**, one about **place** and one about **manner**.

💡 **Parent Tip:** While reading together, pause on a sentence and ask: "What does the writer want us to notice first?" Then try changing the starting words and see how the feeling changes.

🎯 My Term 1 Goal: This term I want to get better at _____

Answer and Teacher Page

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ANSWERS

1. After lunch, the class waited quietly in the library.

2. On Monday night, a storm hit the coast.

3. From the gum tree, the kookaburra laughed.

4. At the end of the day / Without a sound / Beneath the old bridge

5. Slowly = manner (how). By the end of Term 1 = time. Behind the shed = place.

6. Across the paddock, the wind howled all night.

7. When the team scored, the students cheered loudly.

8. Sample: Along the track, the ranger walked quietly. Soon, a koala came into view. With a steady hand, the ranger took a photo. (Accept any version with varied, linking starting points and commas after opening phrases.)

9. The new version puts the place (the valley) first, so the reader looks at the land before the danger arrives. Saving "the bushfire" for last builds suspense. Accept reasoned responses.

10. Open response. See checklist below.

TEACHER NOTES

Marking checklist for Q10: three sentences • one starts with time, one with place, one with manner • a comma after each opening phrase • ideas link logically from one sentence to the next.
Common errors: forgetting the comma after the opening phrase, or changing the meaning when moving a phrase (check that the same information is kept).
Support: have students cut sentences into chunks and rearrange them.
Australian Curriculum v9.0: AC9E5LA04 (Year 5 review): understand how texts can be made cohesive by using the starting point of a sentence or paragraph to give prominence to the message and to guide the reader through the text.